

element and its padding and border is calculated as the combined values of that container's width plus its padding and border. This means that a 300px container is 300px plus values for padding and border. This is how it should be. However, IE5 and IE5.5 get this wrong by subtracting the widths of the border and padding from the width value. This means that a 300px container ends up being much narrower. If padding is declared as 20px, then the actual width of the container in these browsers will be $300 - 20 - 20$, equaling 260 pixels.

Let's examine this using the following simple declaration as an example:

```
/* Sidebar_a */
#sidebar_a {
width:300px;
padding:10px;
border:10px solid #000;
}
```

Although the sidebar itself is 300 pixels in width, the space required to accommodate it needs to be equal or greater than all the widths added together. This will be border-left + padding-left + width + padding-right + border-right, which equates to $10 + 10 + 300 + 10 + 10$, giving a total width of 340 pixels.

With the Box Model under your belt, you can fix your widths with confidence. For this example, we'll take the liquid floated three-column layout created earlier. Here's the HTML again:

```
<div id="masthead">
...masthead content goes here...
</div>
<div id="sidebar_a">
...sidebar content goes here...
</div>
<div id="sidebar_b">
...sidebar content goes here...
</div>
<div id="content">
...main content goes here...
</div>
<div id="footer">
...footer content goes here...
</div>
```